

# BRIAN MORMAN

Marketing and Consumer Focus - Case write-up - Mattel / Barbie

What are the main issues that Barbie (the brand) is facing at the time of the case?

The Barbie brand is facing some questions around the positivity of their brand image and purpose. The “Barbie Body” was brought under heavy scrutiny as an unrealistic role model for girls to live up to due to her impossible body proportions and several product design mistakes that pointed towards an impossible and unhealthy body standard for women and girls. These challenges were significant towards the brand's success but what inflated the issues even more, was the way in which they directly conflict with the brand's intended identity. When Barbie was brought to market in 1959, her original designer, Ruth Handler, said: “Every little girl needed a doll through which to project herself into her dream of her future”. The Barbie doll and brand identity was built on being more than just a doll to play with but also a vision of a potential future for the children who play with her. The reason this issue was so substantial for the Barbie brand is the direct conflict between their stated goal and the reality of how the product went about meeting it.

What is your analysis of Mattel's repositioning efforts, including its new advertisements and new products (as described in the case)?

Through the years Mattel took several approaches to their response to the Brand's identity crisis. In 2014, the brand put Barbie on the cover of Sports Illustrated's swimsuit edition and ran with #unapologetic as a social media campaign. I would say that this 2014 approach is a viable one for the brand to take. They could choose to lean into the product they have, accept its flawed image and remain authentic to the product they are currently making. I personally feel this was a very poor choice. On both a business and human level I find this decision to be the wrong one. In my opinion, this strategy chooses a side in a lose/lose debate for Mattel and alienates potential customers. In 2015 they began introducing new product lines and running promotions including "Imagine the Possibilities" to refocus the brand's image on the positives of their brand ID. This effort and campaign are growth minded, they allow the original character to remain for those that know and love it and opens doors for those who want to see a change. By 2015, barbie had vastly expanded the diversity of their product offering. With the benefit of hindsight this change was obviously the right one. It remains true to the brand identity and allows consumers to choose a role model that looks more like them and doesn't become unrecognizable from what the Brand has been. With a quick look at the financials after this case. Barbie's rebrand was the right decision. If I were a brand consultant, I would next recommend they make a film directed by Greta Gerwig to leverage brand nostalgia and bring the multitude of character to life 😊.